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of things from no kissing on the screen to no drinking anywhere. My father could drink at home in Bombay only after getting a permit from the Collector of Customs. It was obtained after his doctor certified that for health reasons my father required two pegs of whisky every night. My father also used his friends in the Indian Armed Forces to get around prohibition. On Indian naval ships the Gandhian injunctions against alcohol did not apply, the old British custom of drinking still prevailed and as soon as his naval friends came onshore, my father was off to the Bombay docks.

The other big prohibition was in relation to food with the 1960s seeing a determined effort to change Indian eating habits. Parliament in the 1960s spent much time debating over famine-stalked parts of the land. At our dining tables we were told that we should eat less rice and have more wheat: so cut out the plate of rice for dinner, have *chapattis* instead.

In West Bengal, the Congress chief minister tried to engineer a more radical change in food habits. Following a tremendous milk shortage, he had the brilliant idea of telling his fellow Bengalis that they should cut down on sweets, most of which were made from milk. The Bengalis were outraged and it made many middle-class Bengalis distrust the Congress and turn to the communists. Whatever else Marx may advocate, he would never target the beloved Bengali *rosogolla*.

Students were told they couldn't sit for their exams unless they underwent three years of training in the NCC.

Now this may be one of the stories that may have gained more in retelling but there was no getting round the Guest Control Order which prohibited any meals for more than 50 people. This led to the most curious wedding receptions. Hundreds gathered in elabo-

with an inventive vocabulary of swear words.

Our military service was justified on the grounds that this was the price we, the first generation of free Indians, had to pay for freedom. But all around us there were people questioning whether this freedom was worth having. In 1964, V.S. Naipaul, after a year in India, produced *An Area of Darkness*, his bleak and deeply pessimistic book about India. A year later came Nirad Chaudhuri's *The Continent of Circe* which argued Indians could only regain their place in the world if they realised they were Europeans. While we could dismiss them as anti-Indians, Chaudhuri was easily lampooned as our home-grown Brit. All around us we could see much that was wrong with our beloved Bharat.

In the third decade of freedom, India was the land of scarcity—a four-year wait for an Ambassador, 12 years for a Fiat. And of the great P—prohibitions in all kinds

rately decorated shamianas, the presents were as lavish as ever, but all that the guests got was a thin slice of vanilla ice cream. In many ways, the biggest P of all concerned foreign travel. With the country facing massive foreign exchange shortages you could only travel abroad if a Form P was authorised by the Reserve Bank of India. But even when Form P was approved, the RBI gave you only £3 in foreign exchange. The joke was that it was enough to pay for a peg of whisky on the Air India flight taking you out of India.

With no television, 'foreign' was increasingly exotic and the restrictions made us long to leave India. Not an escape but a temporary flight so we could return and make good the deficiencies we saw in a land that we still loved so much.

After 12 years with The Telegraph, the author is now with BBC Sports.